



BEFORE

After April 9, 1865, when General Lee's Army of Northern Virginia laid down its arms (see [The Appomattox Campaign](#)), most of the South's generals accepted that the cause was lost.

DIEHARD RESISTANCE

Some Southern leaders, however, **wanted to fight on**. The most prominent of these diehards, **Confederate President Jefferson Davis was still urging resistance** three weeks after Lee's surrender. By then, he and his cabinet had abandoned the Confederate capital, Richmond, and **fled south to Greensboro, North Carolina**. The cabinet met for the last time on May 5, 1865, in Washington, Georgia, after which Davis went into hiding.

A NEW PRESIDENT

Meanwhile, events in Washington, D.C. had taken a dramatic turn with the [assassination of President Lincoln](#), fatally shot on April 14. Lincoln was succeeded by his vice president, the Southern War Democrat [Andrew Johnson](#), who was swiftly sworn in as **17th President of the United States** on the morning after the shooting.

By far the largest and best organized of the Confederate armies remaining in the field after Lee's surrender was the one confronting General William T. Sherman in North Carolina under the command of General Joseph E. Johnston. Here, the balance of power had altered in late March 1865, when Sherman made a successful rendezvous with reinforcements from Wilmington. Confronted with the Union's overwhelming superiority in numbers, Johnston retreated westward to the North Carolina state capital, Raleigh.

Meeting with Davis

Johnston was preparing to abandon Raleigh to Sherman's advancing Union forces when word came of events at Appomattox. While still digesting the news, Johnston was summoned to a meeting with Confederate President Jefferson Davis in Greensboro, about 80 miles (130km) away. When the two men met on April 12, Davis—without even requesting Johnston's opinion of the military situation—talked ramblingly of gathering up deserters to fight on. Once Johnston was eventually given a chance to speak, he was blunt: "My views are, sir, that our people are tired of war, feel themselves